The Poet of Protest

IT WAS JUNE 1997, AND INDIA HAD JUST GOT its first Dalit president in K.R. Narayanan. In Tamil Nadu's Madurai district, that milestone stood blackened against reality. A month before that, Murugesan, president of the SC-reserved Melavalavu panchayat, was hacked to death for contesting the village polls. Meena Kandasamy, who was 14, lived in Chennai and came from a mixed-caste family, remembers those days. "I grew up in the '90s, a period of great brutality against Dalits in Tamil Nadu. They could have a Dalit as the country's president but not of a village. I was structurally angry.... Poetry is how I poured out my emotions. You got to park your broken heart, your anger somewhere." That sense of hurt still powers the work of Kandasamy, a poet, translator, activist and feminist. One of India's most radical literary voices, she won German PEN Centre's Hermann Kesten prize for her work on caste and gender oppression in 2022. Her new book of poems, *Tomorrow Someone Will Arrest You*, explores practising resistance in a hostile world.

Born to university professor parents who got married under the self-respect marriage law, Kandasamy started translating Dalit works into English when she was 17. By 2001, she was editing the English magazine *The Dalit*. Her two poetry collections, *Touch* (2006) and *Ms. Militancy* (2010), propelled her to fame. Her first novel, *The Gypsy Goddess* (2014), is an incisive retelling of the 1968 massacre of 44 Dalit villagers in Kilvenmani. Kandasamy was never one to write about her personal life. "I didn't want to be caged as a 'victim'.... I wanted to be taken seriously politically and intellectually."

That changed when she married in 2011, only to suffer months of abuse. In a 2012 essay, she wrote searingly about that painful period. Her second novel, *When I Hit You: Or, a Portrait of the Artist As a Young Wife* (2017), merged the personal with the political. "I took it as an artistic project. That essay came from a personal space, but the book came from an artistic space," she says.

Kandasamy's powerful female voices and razor-sharp prose are in contrast to her modest bearing. But she is not one to be dragged down by criticism—she gets a fair share on the internet. "The trolls end up proving the point I'm trying to make." Only a provocation, she says, will start a conversation. ■

–Harshita Mishra



A R SUMANTH KUMAR

Meena Kandasamy, 39
Author, Poet, Translator, Activist

ACCOMPLISHMENT

Winner of German PEN Centre's Hermann Kesten prize, Meena Kandasamy is one of the most radical voices on the Indian literary stage today

FIGHTING SPIRIT

"Stay radical—we have come this far on the back of our mothers' struggles. The world would try to blunt your edge...don't give in"

THE INFLUENCERS

Kamala Das, Arundhati Roy, Eduardo Galeano, Sylvia Plath, Lenin